ENGLISH C2 · ADVANCED GRAMMAR

Anaphora and cataphora

Build reference chains that point backward or forward across clauses while preventing competition between possible antecedents. The lesson connects form, meaning, register and real editorial decisions rather than treating the pattern as an isolated rule.

THE CENTRAL IDEA

Use anaphora and cataphora to maintain continuity and suspense with references that remain immediately interpretable while preserving the intended meaning and register.

Build reference chains that point backward or forward across clauses while preventing competition between possible antecedents.

MODEL

Although it was controversial, the decision passed by a wide margin.

referential item <-> explicit antecedent or postponed referent

6 GUIDED STAGES · 30 LEARNING DECISIONS

This complete guide combines explanation, visual reasoning, practice and feedback. Separate exercise and answer-key editions are also available from the lesson page.

LEARNING OUTCOMES

OUTCOME 1

01

Recognise the main anaphora and cataphora patterns in authentic contexts.

OUTCOME 2

02

Choose a form that accurately expresses maintain continuity and suspense with references that remain immediately interpretable.

OUTCOME 3

03

Avoid errors that change time, agency, emphasis or speaker commitment.

OUTCOME 4

04

Use the structure appropriately in all extended discourse, especially literary and analytical prose.

Build meaning before form

Build reference chains that point backward or forward across clauses while preventing competition between possible antecedents.

What anaphora and cataphora communicates

Build reference chains that point backward or forward across clauses while preventing competition between possible antecedents.

The central purpose is to maintain continuity and suspense with references that remain immediately interpretable. A successful choice therefore preserves the proposition while making the intended relationship, viewpoint or degree of commitment visible to the reader.

The proposal divided the panel. It nevertheless passed.	a later item referring back to an established entity
Although it was controversial, the decision passed by a wide margin.	a reference whose full noun phrase appears later
The evidence was withheld for weeks. This delay compromised the inquiry.	a preceding event recategorised as a discourse object

How the pattern is built

Use this working formula: referential item <-> explicit antecedent or postponed referent. The formula is a decision path: it identifies the trigger, the clause architecture and the element that carries tense or modality.

The model “Although it was controversial, the decision passed by a wide margin.” shows the complete pattern in context. Rebuild the sentence from meaning to form instead of translating each word independently.

Choice	Structure	Example
Anaphoric reference	referential item after antecedent	The proposal divided the panel. It nevertheless passed.
Cataphoric reference	referential item before postponed referent	Although it was controversial, the decision passed by a wide margin.
Demonstrative summary	this/that + summary noun	The evidence was withheld for weeks. This delay compromised the inquiry.

Choose by meaning, not by surface similarity

Neighbouring structures may contain similar words but perform different jobs. Compare the three reference patterns and name the intended effect before completing the sentence.

A reliable answer explains both why the chosen form works and why a plausible alternative would change the meaning, time relation, information focus or level of certainty.

Meaning	Best route
a later item referring back to an established entity	Anaphoric reference
a reference whose full noun phrase appears later	Cataphoric reference
a preceding event recategorised as a discourse object	Demonstrative summary

Register, discourse and editorial control

This grammar is especially useful in all extended discourse, especially literary and analytical prose. Its value comes from helping the reader process a relationship efficiently, not from making the sentence sound artificially complex.

After editing, check recoverability, natural word order and consistency with the surrounding paragraph. If the marked structure creates ambiguity, return to a fuller or more neutral clause.

Reason through the pattern

The visual map moves from communicative purpose to structural trigger, then to the final clause. It keeps meaning and form visible at the same time so the learner can justify every choice.

01

referential item <-> explicit antecedent or postponed referent

DECIDE IN THIS ORDER

STEP 1

Decision 1

Identify the communicative purpose before selecting a form: maintain continuity and suspense with references that remain immediately interpretable.

STEP 2

Decision 2

Locate the structural trigger and match it to one of the reference patterns.

STEP 3

Decision 3

Check time reference, clause relationships, agency and speaker commitment.

STEP 4

Decision 4

Read the complete sentence in context and confirm that its register suits all extended discourse, especially literary and analytical prose.

STEP 5

Decision 5

Compare the result with a neutral alternative and keep the marked form only when it adds useful meaning.

Compare forms and meanings

Use the table to justify each structural choice.

Pattern	Form	Model
Anaphoric reference	referential item after antecedent	The proposal divided the panel. It nevertheless passed.
Cataphoric reference	referential item before postponed referent	Although it was controversial, the decision passed by a wide margin.
Demonstrative summary	this/that + summary noun	The evidence was withheld for weeks. This delay compromised the inquiry.

EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

The proposal divided the panel. It nevertheless passed.	a later item referring back to an established entity
Although it was controversial, the decision passed by a wide margin.	a reference whose full noun phrase appears later
The evidence was withheld for weeks. This delay compromised the inquiry.	a preceding event recategorised as a discourse object

COMMON ERRORS

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Do not use a pronoun when two equally plausible antecedents compete.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Use cataphora only when the postponed referent arrives quickly and clearly.

EDIT THIS

Avoid this pattern

Choose a summary noun that accurately characterises the preceding proposition.

Recognition in context

Choose the sentence whose grammar matches the stated communicative purpose.

A1 · MEANING DECISION 1

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a later item referring back to an established entity?

OPTIONS The proposal divided the panel. It nevertheless passed. · Although it was controversial, the decision passed by a wide margin. · The evidence was withheld for weeks. This delay compromised the inquiry.

A2 · MEANING DECISION 2

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a reference whose full noun phrase appears later?

OPTIONS Although it was controversial, the decision passed by a wide margin. · The evidence was withheld for weeks. This delay compromised the inquiry. · The proposal divided the panel. It nevertheless passed.

A3 · MEANING DECISION 3

Which sentence best communicates this purpose: a preceding event recategorised as a discourse object?

OPTIONS The evidence was withheld for weeks. This delay compromised the inquiry. · The proposal divided the panel. It nevertheless passed. · Although it was controversial, the decision passed by a wide margin.

A4 · INTERPRETATION 4

What does “The proposal divided the panel. It nevertheless passed.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a later item referring back to an established entity · a reference whose full noun phrase appears later · a preceding event recategorised as a discourse object

A5 · INTERPRETATION 5

What does “Although it was controversial, the decision passed by a wide margin.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a reference whose full noun phrase appears later · a preceding event recategorised as a discourse object · a later item referring back to an established entity

A6 · INTERPRETATION 6

What does “The evidence was withheld for weeks. This delay compromised the inquiry.” communicate in this context?

OPTIONS a preceding event recategorised as a discourse object · a later item referring back to an established entity · a reference whose full noun phrase appears later

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Form and function

Identify both the structural family and the meaning carried by each model.

B1 · FORM AND FUNCTION 1

"The proposal divided the panel. It nevertheless passed." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Anaphoric reference / Cataphoric reference / Demonstrative summary · Gap 2: a later item referring back to an established entity / a reference whose full noun phrase appears later / a preceding event recategorised as a discourse object

B2 · FORM AND FUNCTION 2

"Although it was controversial, the decision passed by a wide margin." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Cataphoric reference / Demonstrative summary / Anaphoric reference · Gap 2: a reference whose full noun phrase appears later / a preceding event recategorised as a discourse object / a later item referring back to an established entity

B3 · FORM AND FUNCTION 3

"The evidence was withheld for weeks. This delay compromised the inquiry." uses _____ to express _____.

OPTIONS Gap 1: Demonstrative summary / Anaphoric reference / Cataphoric reference · Gap 2: a preceding event recategorised as a discourse object / a later item referring back to an established entity / a reference whose full noun phrase appears later

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Guided discourse choices

Maintain accurate form and meaning across a connected sequence of decisions.

C1 · EDITORIAL PLANNING

Choose the model that expresses a later item referring back to an established entity: _____. Choose the model that expresses a reference whose full noun phrase appears later: _____. Choose the model that expresses a preceding event recategorised as a discourse object: _____. Choose the model built with referential item after antecedent: _____. Choose the model built with referential item before postponed referent: _____. Choose the model built with this/that + summary noun: _____.

_____
_____

WORD BANK

Available forms

Although it was controversial, the decision passed by a wide margin. · The evidence was withheld for weeks. This delay compromised the inquiry. · The proposal divided the panel. It nevertheless passed.

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Open reconstruction

Recover the missing structural trigger without a word bank.

D1 · INDEPENDENT RECONSTRUCTION

The proposal divided the panel. _____. Although _____, the decision passed by a wide margin. The evidence was withheld for weeks. _____ compromised the inquiry. State the full structural pattern for Anaphoric reference: _____. State the full structural pattern for Cataphoric reference: _____.

_____
_____
_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Controlled transformation

Rewrite the neutral source so that it performs the requested advanced function.

E1 · TRANSFORMATION 1

Rewrite “The proposal divided the panel but still passed.” using the Anaphoric reference pattern to express a later item referring back to an established entity.

_____
_____

E2 · TRANSFORMATION 2

Rewrite “The controversial decision passed by a wide margin.” using the Cataphoric reference pattern to express a reference whose full noun phrase appears later.

_____
_____

E3 · TRANSFORMATION 3

Rewrite “Withholding the evidence delayed and damaged the inquiry.” using the Demonstrative summary pattern to express a preceding event recategorised as a discourse object.

_____
_____

E4 · TRANSFORMATION 4

Rewrite “The proposal divided the panel but still passed.” using the Anaphoric reference pattern to express a later item referring back to an established entity.

_____
_____

STAGE CHECK

Pause before continuing

Underline the trigger or decision point, name the rule, and check that the meaning has not changed.

Communicative production

Use the grammar independently in realistic academic, professional and conversational contexts.

F1 · PRODUCTION TASK 1

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Anaphoric reference to express a later item referring back to an established entity, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F2 · PRODUCTION TASK 2

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Cataphoric reference to express a reference whose full noun phrase appears later, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

F3 · PRODUCTION TASK 3

Write two connected sentences about a realistic situation. Use Demonstrative summary to express a preceding event recategorised as a discourse object, then add a neutral sentence that makes the contrast clear.

_____
_____
_____

Final self-check

Complete these prompts without reopening the guide.

R1 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: communicative purpose.

_____
_____
_____

R2 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: structural trigger.

_____
_____
_____

R3 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: meaning contrast.

_____
_____
_____

R4 · REVIEW FOCUS

Explain and exemplify: register choice.

_____
_____
_____

Recognition in context

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

A1

The proposal divided the panel. It nevertheless passed.

Anaphoric reference is the best match because a later item referring back to an established entity.

A2

Although it was controversial, the decision passed by a wide margin.

Cataphoric reference is the best match because a reference whose full noun phrase appears later.

A3

The evidence was withheld for weeks. This delay compromised the inquiry.

Demonstrative summary is the best match because a preceding event recategorised as a discourse object.

A4

a later item referring back to an established entity

The Anaphoric reference pattern communicates a later item referring back to an established entity.

A5

a reference whose full noun phrase appears later

The Cataphoric reference pattern communicates a reference whose full noun phrase appears later.

A6

a preceding event recategorised as a discourse object

The Demonstrative summary pattern communicates a preceding event recategorised as a discourse object.

Form and function

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

B1

Anaphoric reference / a later item referring back to an established entity

The structure belongs to the Anaphoric reference pattern. Its communicative purpose is a later item referring back to an established entity.

B2

Cataphoric reference / a reference whose full noun phrase appears later

The structure belongs to the Cataphoric reference pattern. Its communicative purpose is a reference whose full noun phrase appears later.

B3

Demonstrative summary / a preceding event recategorised as a discourse object

The structure belongs to the Demonstrative summary pattern. Its communicative purpose is a preceding event recategorised as a discourse object.

Guided discourse choices

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

C1

The proposal divided the panel. It nevertheless passed.

Anaphoric reference: referential item after antecedent.

C2

Although it was controversial, the decision passed by a wide margin.

Cataphoric reference: referential item before postponed referent.

C3

The evidence was withheld for weeks. This delay compromised the inquiry.

Demonstrative summary: this/that + summary noun.

C4

The proposal divided the panel. It nevertheless passed.

Anaphoric reference: referential item after antecedent.

C5

Although it was controversial, the decision passed by a wide margin.

Cataphoric reference: referential item before postponed referent.

C6

The evidence was withheld for weeks. This delay compromised the inquiry.

Demonstrative summary: this/that + summary noun.

Open reconstruction

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

D1

It nevertheless passed

Anaphoric reference requires “It nevertheless passed” in this model. referential item after antecedent.

D2

it was controversial

Cataphoric reference requires “it was controversial” in this model. referential item before postponed referent.

D3

This delay

Demonstrative summary requires “This delay” in this model. this/that + summary noun.

D4

referential item after antecedent

Anaphoric reference is built as referential item after antecedent.

D5

referential item before postponed referent

Cataphoric reference is built as referential item before postponed referent.

Controlled transformation

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

E1

The proposal divided the panel. It nevertheless passed.

referential item after antecedent. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended anaphoric reference effect.

E2

Although it was controversial, the decision passed by a wide margin.

referential item before postponed referent. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended cataphoric reference effect.

E3

The evidence was withheld for weeks. This delay compromised the inquiry.

this/that + summary noun. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended demonstrative summary effect.

E4

The proposal divided the panel. It nevertheless passed.

referential item after antecedent. The rewrite preserves the core message while adding the intended anaphoric reference effect.

Communicative production

Compare the form first, then read the explanation and name the rule in your own words.

F1

The proposal divided the panel. It nevertheless passed. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses referential item after antecedent accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F2

Although it was controversial, the decision passed by a wide margin. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses referential item before postponed referent accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

F3

The evidence was withheld for weeks. This delay compromised the inquiry. The surrounding context would then state the same situation in neutral order or with a less marked commitment.

A strong response uses this/that + summary noun accurately and makes the communicative purpose visible in context.

Diagnose the pattern, not only the score

Use this page to decide what to revisit in the complete guide.

CHECK · TRIGGER OR CONTEXT

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · AUXILIARY OR STRUCTURAL CHOICE

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MAIN VERB OR CLAUSE FORM

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____

CHECK · MEANING AND REGISTER

What went wrong? What rule will prevent the same error next time?

_____
_____
_____